Kennedy's European visit began propitiously. En route to Vienna he visited Paris to meet President Charles de Gaulle. The trip was a great success. Jacqueline Kennedy ingratiated herself with Parisians and indeed with *le President* (her fluent French reflecting the year she had spent at the Sorbonne). The Kennedys were received with adulation by crowds lining the streets. But behind the public triumph, Kennedy was plagued by agonising back pain. His private physician, Max Jacobson, treated him with a cocktail of drugs. When warned that 'Dr Feelgood' was injecting him with steroids and amphetamines, Kennedy responded, 'I don't care if it's horse piss. It works.'[12] Michael Beschloss records that the side effects of amphetamines 'include nervousness, garrulousness, impaired judgement, overconfidence, and, when the drug wears off, depression'.[13] This was a man whose impaired judgement could kill hundreds of millions of people.

The President also ignored the counsel of his advisers on how to deal with Khrushchev. At their first meeting on 3 June 1961, he was drawn into a counterproductive discussion about the ideological merits of capitalism and communism. Khrushchev was unyielding on the strengths of Marxism-Leninism and then took strong exception to Kennedy's concern that 'miscalculation' might lead to confrontation. Afterwards, JFK told Kenny O'Donnell that Khrushchev had gone 'berserk' when he used the word.[14] How far Khrushchev's behaviour was contrived and how far a genuine emotional response was difficult for JFK to judge. When Kennedy described his own actions over Cuba in April 1961 as a 'misjudgement', Khrushchev was rather less volatile and later expressed some admiration for Kennedy's honesty.

Dealing with Khrushchev meant disentangling contrivance from calculation. This was all the more difficult because Khrushchev would switch from belligerence to emollience within minutes. Harold Macmillan described him as 'obscene figure', and wondered how 'this fat, vulgar man, with his pig eyes and ceaseless flow of talk' could really be the head of a great country.[15] More worrying for Western leaders was that Khrushchev's threats included the threat of nuclear war.

There was a further problem with Khrushchev's mercurial and volatile temperament. It was not so much whether his adversaries knew what was at